MADRID, SPAIN

Museo del Prado: Masterpieces

Twenty paintings of rulers, workers, witnesses and people under threat.



In *Las Meninas*, the painter looks out of the room toward a position that may also belong to the royal sitters. In Goya's execution scene, the victims expose their faces while the soldiers turn their backs. These are very different paintings, but both make the viewer's position part of the problem.

The selection follows such distributions of visibility and power. A key passes between commanders; a cardinal needs almost no setting to establish rank; workers occupy the foreground of a myth. Religious images and scenes of violence ask who supports a body, who watches it, and who remains unseen. This is a set of comparisons within the collection, not a room-by-room itinerary.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/prado

The selection · 20

1. Las Meninas
   Diego Velázquez · 1656
2. The Garden of Earthly Delights
   Hieronymus Bosch · 1490–1500
3. The Descent from the Cross
   Rogier van der Weyden · Before 1443
4. The Third of May 1808
   Francisco Goya · 1814
5. The Surrender of Breda
   Diego Velázquez · Ca. 1635
6. The Spinners, or the Fable of Arachne
   Diego Velázquez · 1655–1660
7. Emperor Charles V at Mühlberg
   Titian · 1548
8. The Cardinal
   Raphael · 1510–1511
9. Self-Portrait, 1498
   Albrecht Dürer · 1498
10. The Adoration of the Shepherds
    El Greco · 1612–1614
11. Saturn
    Francisco Goya · 1820–1823
12. The Naked Maja
    Francisco Goya · 1795–1800
13. The Clothed Maja
    Francisco Goya · 1800–1807
14. Apollo in the Forge of Vulcan
    Diego Velázquez · 1630
15. David and Goliath
    Caravaggio · 1599
16. The Triumph of Death
    Pieter Bruegel the Elder · 1562–1563
17. The Family of Charles IV
    Francisco Goya · 1800
18. The Feast of Bacchus
    Diego Velázquez · 1628–1629
19. Christ Crucified
    Diego Velázquez · c. 1632
20. The Trinity
    El Greco · 1577–1579

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Las Meninas

Diego Velázquez

1656 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional del Prado



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The large canvas withholds what Velázquez is painting. Instead, his outward gaze, the royal figures in the rear mirror and the open doorway establish competing positions around the visible group. The room is convincing enough to enter imaginatively, but the viewer's place within it remains unsettled. That uncertainty belongs to the portrait's construction, not to a missing piece of scenery.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P001174

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The Garden of Earthly Delights

Hieronymus Bosch

1490–1500 · Oil on wood panel · Museo Nacional del Prado



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Before pursuing an individual fruit or hybrid creature, follow the changing conditions across the panels. Open landscape gives way to crowded pleasure, then to darkness and punishment. Bodies recur, but what surrounds and happens to them alters drastically. The hinges separate stages of the argument even when the abundance of small incidents makes the eye reluctant to move on.

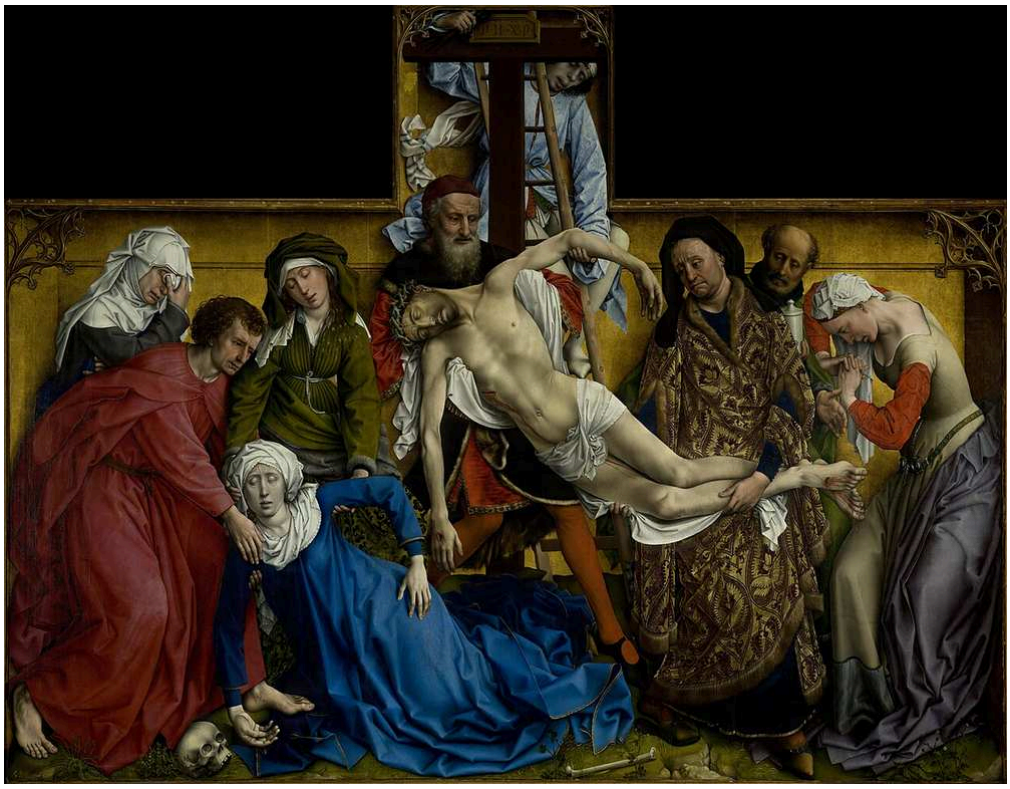
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P002823

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The Descent from the Cross

Rogier van der Weyden

Before 1443 · Oil on wood panel · Museo Nacional del Prado



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The Virgin's collapsing body repeats the inclination of Christ's. Around this correspondence, other mourners perform distinct actions: supporting, bending, wiping tears. Grief is shared without being made uniform. The shallow golden enclosure gives the figures little room to withdraw, bringing their gestures together almost as a relief while preserving the particular pressure of each pair of hands.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P002825

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The Third of May 1808

Francisco Goya

1814 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional del Prado



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The lantern exposes the prisoners and leaves the firing squad largely without faces. White shirt and raised arms isolate one man between the dead before him and those still waiting. Goya gives the sequence of execution a spatial form. The soldiers' repeated backs and weapons confront people whose individual reactions remain visible, making the exchange deliberately unequal.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P000749

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The Surrender of Breda

Diego Velázquez

Ca. 1635 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional del Prado



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An army's victory is concentrated into the transfer of a small key. Spears, soldiers and the scarred landscape establish the event's scale, but the commanders' encounter determines how victory is presented. The victor's conduct toward the defeated man matters as much as possession of the town. A restrained gesture carries an otherwise expansive public account of power.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P001172

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The Spinners, or the Fable of Arachne

Diego Velázquez

1655–1660 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional del Prado



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The finished tapestry is farther away than the labour of making thread. Workers and a spinning wheel occupy the dim foreground; a brighter raised space opens behind them onto the mythic subject. The division makes production difficult to overlook. Cloth appears both as something handled through practical skill and as a surface capable of carrying an elaborate story.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P001173

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Emperor Charles V at Mühlberg

Titian

1548 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional del Prado



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The battle is represented through a mounted ruler rather than through fighting troops. Armour, lance and command of the horse make military success part of Charles's bearing. Red cloth connects rider and mount against the glowing sky. With so few competing actors, the portrait can present an entire victory as something concentrated in the emperor's person.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P000410

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The Cardinal

Raphael

1510–1511 · Oil on wood panel · Museo Nacional del Prado



Rafael Sanzio. The Cardinal. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

Red identifies the sitter's office before a setting can explain it. The pale face and white sleeve interrupt that broad colour, giving small changes of position considerable force. Raphael establishes authority through a direct gaze and controlled turn of the body. Compare the economy of this arrangement with the many costumes and faces in Goya's royal family.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P000299

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Self-Portrait, 1498

Albrecht Dürer

1498 · Oil on wood panel · Museo Nacional del Prado



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Dürer's carefully dressed figure occupies the role of a distinguished sitter. The gloved hands remain composed, while curls and fabric receive close attention. A window gives the portrait a distance beyond the body. This turned, socially presented figure differs from the later frontal self-portrait in Munich; the two pictures make separate claims through posture and setting.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P002179

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The Adoration of the Shepherds

El Greco

1612–1614 · Museo Nacional del Prado



Adoración de los pastores. El Greco; El Greco; [1]; © Madrid, Museo Nacional del Prado. Source terms: https://www.museodelprado.es/en/legal-information. Commons asserts: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full supplied composition. · Prado reproduction terms; Commons label: Public domain

The tall format puts the gathering under upward pressure. Elongated bodies bend toward the child and extend into the space above, with light linking faces and robes through the crowded scene. Exact physical positions can be difficult to untangle. Colour and illumination supply another route through the group, keeping the devotional centre legible within the movement.

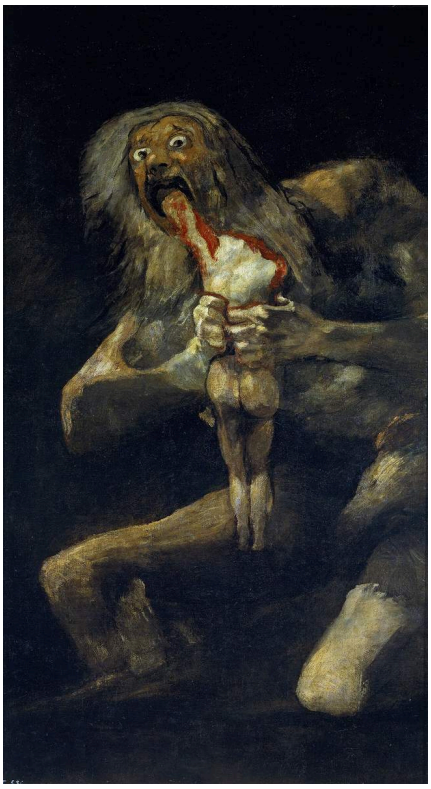
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P002988

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Saturn

Francisco Goya

1820–1823 · Mixed technique on a wall, transferred to canvas · Museo Nacional del Prado



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There is almost nowhere else to look. Darkness removes the setting, leaving grasping hands, a wide-eyed face and the mutilated body pressed to the mouth. The myth has been stripped of a surrounding assembly of gods or witnesses. Violence fills the available encounter with the image, without an explanatory spectator to stand between the act and its viewer.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P000763

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The Naked Maja

Francisco Goya

1795–1800 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional del Prado



Francisco de Goya. The Naked Maja. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The reclining figure meets the viewer's gaze with her hands placed behind her head. White pillows extend the body's horizontal position against the darkness. Comparison with *The Clothed Maja* can begin with what remains stable: posture, setting and the outward look. Clothing changes the painted surface considerably without providing a simple explanation of the sitter's expression.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P000742

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The Clothed Maja

Francisco Goya

1800–1807 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional del Prado



Francisco Goya. The Clothed Maja. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The white costume introduces folds and seams along the reclining body, while the darker jacket interrupts its length. These are compositional changes as well as a difference in coverage. Keeping the related nude nearby in mind helps separate the work performed by clothing from that performed by pose. The direct gaze does not disappear beneath the added ornament.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P000741

14 / 20

Apollo in the Forge of Vulcan

Diego Velázquez

1630 · Museo Nacional del Prado



Diego Velázquez. Apollo in the Forge of Vulcan. Image credit: Diego Velázquez; Own work , user:Luestling. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public domain

The news arrives before the workers can put their tools away. Apollo's entrance interrupts a sequence of bodily tasks, leaving each man caught in a different position. Myth becomes intelligible through that broken routine. Surprise does not require a repeated theatrical gesture when a turning head or a suddenly arrested hand can show work being stopped.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P001171

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David and Goliath

Caravaggio

1599 · Museo Nacional del Prado



Caravaggio. David and Goliath. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

David bends over the severed head rather than standing clear of it in triumph. His face turns down, and the illuminated arms emphasise what he must still handle after the battle. The dark setting leaves little space for spectators or public celebration. Victory has an awkward physical aftermath, which Caravaggio keeps close to the front of the picture.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

The Triumph of Death

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

1562–1563 · Oil on wood panel · Museo Nacional del Prado



El triunfo de la Muerte. Pieter Bruegel el Viejo; Pieter Brueghel the Elder; Museo del Prado; © Madrid, Museo Nacional del Prado. Source terms: https://www.museodelprado.es/en/legal-information. Commons asserts: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full supplied composition. · Prado reproduction terms; Commons label: Public domain

Following one attempted escape leads into another catastrophe. Bruegel disperses the action across ranks and settings, making accumulation more important than a single protagonist. Fires and ruined buildings continue the threat into the distance. The many small episodes offer ample detail but little relief: the eye can travel widely without finding a part of society outside death's reach.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P001393

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The Family of Charles IV

Francisco Goya

1800 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional del Prado



Francisco Goya. The Family of Carlos IV. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

Ceremonial clothes display a dynasty, while separate faces resist becoming a uniform emblem. Goya places himself in shadow at the side, allowing the royal group to occupy the breadth of the canvas. Unlike the uncertain exchanges in *Las Meninas*, this arrangement holds its sitters before sustained inspection. Individuality need not be mistaken for evidence of a hidden caricature.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P000726

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The Feast of Bacchus

Diego Velázquez

1628–1629 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional del Prado



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Bacchus's pale, partly undressed body remains distinct from his clothed companions, but everyone occupies the same gathering. A wreath supplies ceremony while nearby faces and everyday dress pull the event toward an ordinary drinking party. The god does not require a separate heavenly zone. The painting's difference of register happens among bodies sitting close together.

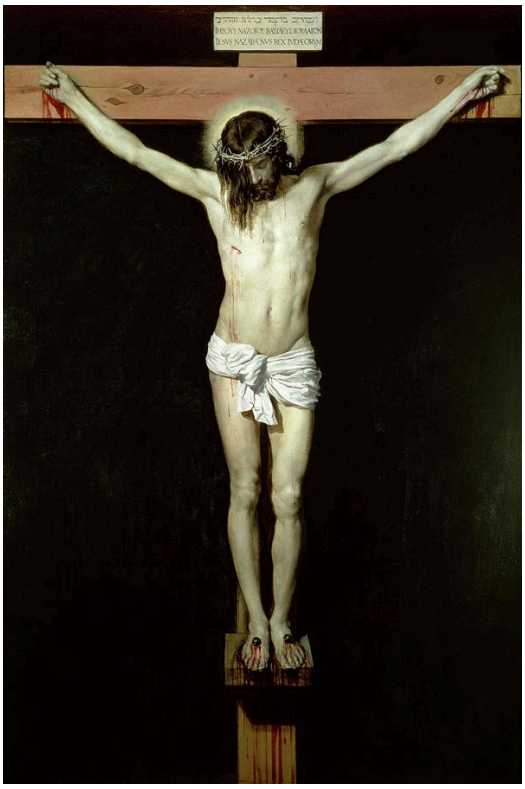
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P001170

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Christ Crucified

Diego Velázquez

c. 1632 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional del Prado



Diego Velazquez. Cristo crucificado. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The dark ground removes almost all narrative surroundings. Christ's lowered head and balanced limbs are left to establish weight against the cross. This concentration gives the image a different pace from El Greco's crowded devotional gatherings. Light does not lead through a succession of figures; it holds attention on one body and the fact of its suspension.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P001167

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The Trinity

El Greco

1577–1579 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional del Prado



La Trinidad. El Greco; El Greco; [2]; © Madrid, Museo Nacional del Prado. Source terms: https://www.museodelprado.es/en/legal-information. Commons asserts: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full supplied composition. · Prado reproduction terms; Commons label: Public domain

The Father's support makes Christ's dead weight visible even within the heavenly gathering. The body pulls diagonally across the composition while angels and robes draw attention upward toward the dove. Those directions do not fully cancel each other. El Greco allows the material difficulty of holding a body to remain inside the theological image.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P000824

Choose a comparison before a route

Two paintings can sustain a visit: the royal groups, the Majas, or the different treatments of Christ's body. Their differences become clearer with time than with a longer checklist. Confirm current display and access through the Prado before planning around a particular work; collection membership alone does not establish availability.

Further reading

Velazquez

S. L. Bensusan · Read free · English

A short illustrated study of Velázquez, published in English in 1907. It records an earlier view of the painter's work; the Prado's current entries should take precedence for dates and attributions.

A Treatise on Painting

Leonardo da Vinci; translated by John Francis Rigaud · Read free · English

Leonardo's notes on observation, proportion and painting, in an older English translation. They offer background on a painter's practical problems; this book does not discuss the Prado's collection.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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